Plan 4 · Sikkim: Gangtok, Silk Route & West Sikkim

Gangtok, Tsomgo Lake & Nathula, the Old Silk Route (Zuluk, Thambi, Nathang, Kupup), Aritar, Ravangla, Pelling, Rinchenpong, Darjeeling. 24 Dec 2026 – 3 Jan 2027 · Fly Hyderabad ↔ Bagdogra

At a glance

Route	HYD ✈ Bagdogra → Gangtok 3N → Zuluk 1N (Silk Route) → Aritar 1N → Ravangla 1N → Pelling 1N → Rinchenpong 1N (NYE) → Darjeeling 2N → Bagdogra ✈ HYD
Snow chances	High: Tsomgo, Nathula, Nathang, Kupup (often frozen lakes). Low–medium: Zuluk. None in Gangtok, Pelling, Darjeeling (but clear Kanchenjunga views are best in Dec–Jan)
Crowd level	Medium in Gangtok and Darjeeling (Christmas/NYE). Low on the Silk Route, Aritar, Ravangla, Rinchenpong
Difficulty	Easy, but high altitude: Nathula 4,310 m, Nathang ~4,100 m. Slow down and stay hydrated
Temperatures	Gangtok 4–13 °C · Pelling/Darjeeling 2–11 °C · Zuluk/Nathang −12 to 0 °C
Budget (per person, 4 people)	≈ ₹35.6k shoestring · ≈ ₹47k comfortable · ≈ ₹31k 'lean version' (see box). **Flights make this the costliest plan.**

Honest budget note

Trains from Hyderabad to New Jalpaiguri take 35–42 h and their weekly days don't line up with 24 Dec (e.g. 15645 Charlapalli–Silchar via NJP runs Wed/Sat; 07572 special runs Fri). With only 10 days, **flying both ways is the practical choice**, and that alone is ₹13–17k.

Lean version to get close to ₹30k: book flights now (aim ≤ ₹6,500 each way), travel as 6 in one Bolero/Sumo, use hostel dorms in Gangtok, take a shared seat to Tsomgo (skip Nathula), and do Gangtok 3N → Silk Route 2N → Pelling 3N → Siliguri, dropping Ravangla, Rinchenpong and Darjeeling (≈ ₹31k).

Getting there and back

Flights Hyderabad ⇄ Bagdogra (main way in and out)

Route (non-stop)	Airlines	Flight time	Typical Dec–Jan one-way fare*	Useful for
Hyderabad ↔ Bagdogra	IndiGo (+ Air India Express)	~2 h 15 m–2 h 30 m	₹6,500–8,500 (peak ₹9–12k)	Plan 4

*Snapshot ranges from MakeMyTrip, Goibibo, Skyscanner, HappyFares and ixigo pages seen in Nov 2026, not live quotes. IndiGo cabin bag: 7 kg; check-in 15 kg on most fares. Winter jackets count, so wear the heaviest layers on the plane. Book within the next 1–2 weeks: Christmas/New Year fares on these routes usually climb steadily.

Leg	Option	Time	Approx cost
Bagdogra (IXB) → Gangtok	Reserved cab (small ₹3,000–3,500; SUV ₹3,500–4,500) or auto to Siliguri SNT / Panitanki then shared Sumo (₹400–550 per seat). Shared cabs don't wait at the airport	4–5 h (125 km)	₹600–1,125 pp
Bagdogra luxury shared seat	Wizzride-type shared SUV seat from IXB/NJP	4–5 h	₹900–1,200 per seat
Darjeeling → Bagdogra	Reserved cab or shared jeep to Siliguri (₹250–350) + auto/taxi to IXB	3–3.5 h	₹450–875 pp

Trains via New Jalpaiguri (only if you can leave or return on matching days)

Train	From Hyderabad	Runs	Duration	Notes
15645 Charlapalli–Silchar Exp (via NJP)	Charlapalli 16:25	Wed / Sat (sources differ)	~35.5 h to NJP	23 Dec Wed would be a day early
15673 Kacheguda–NJP Amrit Bharat	Kacheguda 19:40	Weekly (verify)	~41 h	Non-AC, cheapest (SL-type)
07572 Secunderabad–NJP special	Secunderabad 06:50	Fri (seasonal)	~38 h	Special train; may not run in Dec
12513/12514 Secunderabad ⇄ Guwahati/Silchar SF	Secunderabad	Weekly	~35 h to NJP	Return 12514 from Guwahati Thu, so NJP Thu → SC Sat 04:00

Alternative: fly Hyderabad → Kolkata (often ₹4–5.5k) + Vande Bharat Howrah → NJP (05:55 → 13:25, CC ≈ ₹1,500). Same cost as a direct Bagdogra flight but loses half a day. Only worth it if Bagdogra fares jump above ₹10k.

Permits (Indian citizens)

Where	Permit	How	Cost
Gangtok, Ravangla, Pelling, Rinchenpong	None	—	—
Tsomgo Lake + Baba Mandir	Protected Area Permit	Registered agent / your hotel applies a day before (submit ID + photos by ~13:00 at MG Marg Tourist Info Centre). No solo permits; groups only	Included in the cab fare
Nathula Pass	Separate Nathula endorsement	Via registered agent, 1-day validity. Indians only. Usually closed Mon/Tue; snow can shut it	Govt fixed cab fare ₹6,500 (normal) / ₹7,000 (luxury) incl. permits
Silk Route: Zuluk, Nathang, Kupup	Restricted Area Permit	Through your Zuluk homestay/driver; issued at Rongli police station on the way	≈ ₹200–300 pp + vehicle pass
Lachung / Yumthang / Zero Point (optional swap)	PAP	Package from Gangtok. Reopening dates vary by report and heavy snow often closes it	₹4,000–6,000 pp 2D/1N package

Carry 4 passport photos and 2 Aadhaar copies per person. Permit counters close early, so give documents to the agent on arrival day.

Day-by-day itinerary

Day 1 · Thu 24 Dec · Hyderabad ✈ Bagdogra → Gangtok

• Morning IndiGo flight (~2 h 20 m). Taxi/shared cab to Gangtok (4–5 h along the Teesta, Rangpo checkpost, no permit for Gangtok).

• Hand over ID + photos to your hotel/agent tonight for the Tsomgo/Nathula permit on Day 3.

• Christmas Eve on **MG Marg** (lit up, no vehicles).

Stay: Gangtok budget hotel / hostel (₹1,500–2,800 per room; dorm ₹500–700) | **Day spend (per person):** ₹875 cab share + ₹600 food

Day 2 · Fri 25 Dec · Gangtok sightseeing (full-day cab ₹3,000–3,500)

• **Rumtek monastery** (Dharma Chakra Centre) → **Lingdum (Ranka) monastery** (offbeat, quiet) → Banjhakri falls → Namgyal Institute of Tibetology → Do Drul Chorten → Enchey monastery.

• **Tashi viewpoint** / **Ganesh Tok** / **Hanuman Tok** for Kanchenjunga at sunset. Gangtok ropeway (short ride).

• Evening: MG Marg Christmas, momos and thukpa at Lal Market side.

Stay: Gangtok | **Day spend (per person):** ₹800 cab share + ₹300 entries + ₹700 food

Day 3 · Sat 26 Dec · Tsomgo Lake · Baba Mandir · Nathula (snow day)

• Leave 07:00 (permit vehicle). **Tsomgo (Changu) Lake**, 3,753 m, often frozen in December. Rent boots/coats at the lake stalls (₹100–200). Yak ride optional.

• **Baba Harbhajan Singh Mandir**, and **Nathula** (4,310 m; Indo-China border, Indians only) if permitted. Govt fixed cab fare ₹6,500–7,000 incl. permits. Tsomgo-only trips ≈ ₹4,500–5,500 per car or ₹1,000–1,500 per shared seat.

• Back by 15:00. Rest; altitude headaches are common.

Stay: Gangtok | **Day spend (per person):** ₹1,700 cab share + ₹200 rent + ₹700 food

Day 4 · Sun 27 Dec · Gangtok → Rongli (permit) → Zuluk · Old Silk Route

• Reserved vehicle for 2 days (≈ ₹10,000–14,000 incl. permits; your Zuluk homestay can arrange). Gangtok → Rongli (permit) → Lingtam → Padamchen → **Zuluk (2,850 m)**, about 4 h.

• Afternoon: **Lungthung** and the view over the 32 hairpin bends of the Zuluk road.

Stay: Zuluk homestay with all meals (₹1,000–1,500 pp) | **Day spend (per person):** ₹1,750 vehicle share + permit

Day 5 · Mon 28 Dec · Thambi sunrise · Nathang valley · Kupup → Aritar

• 04:45 drive to **Thambi viewpoint** for Kanchenjunga sunrise over the zig-zag road.

• **Nathang valley** (~4,100 m, often snowy, −10 °C), **Kupup / Elephant lake** (frozen), **Old Baba Mandir**, Tukla valley memorial.

• Descend to **Aritar**: **Lampokhari lake** (boot-shaped lake, boating), **Mankhim** viewpoint, Aritar gumpa.

Stay: Aritar homestay / lake-side lodge (₹1,500–2,500 per room) | **Day spend (per person):** ₹1,750 vehicle share + ₹700 food

Day 6 · Tue 29 Dec · Aritar → Temi → Ravangla

• Drive via Rorathang–Singtam (≈ ₹3,500 per car, or shared jeeps with 1–2 changes).

• **Temi Tea Garden** (Sikkim's only tea estate), **Buddha Park (Tathagata Tsal)** with its 130 ft Buddha, **Ralang monastery** (offbeat).

Stay: Ravangla homestay (₹1,200–2,000 per room) | **Day spend (per person):** ₹875 cab share + ₹100 entry + ₹700 food

Day 7 · Wed 30 Dec · Ravangla → Pelling (West Sikkim)

• Shared jeep via Legship (₹200–300) or cab (₹2,800–3,500).

• **Pelling Skywalk & Chenrezig statue**, **Pemayangtse monastery**, **Rabdentse ruins** (17th-c. capital), sunset over Kanchenjunga.

Stay: Pelling budget hotel (₹1,500–2,500 per room) | **Day spend (per person):** ₹700 transfer share + ₹200 entries + ₹700 food

Day 8 · Thu 31 Dec · Khecheopalri lake · Kanchenjunga falls → Rinchenpong (quiet NYE)

• Half-day cab: **Khecheopalri (wishing) lake**, **Kanchenjunga falls**, Rimbi falls.

• Short drive to **Rinchenpong** (offbeat): **Resum monastery** walk, Poison Lake, Kaluk. Kanchenjunga sunset across the valley. NYE bonfire at a homestay.

Stay: Rinchenpong homestay (₹1,200–2,000 per room) | **Day spend (per person):** ₹1,125 cab share + ₹800 food/NYE

Day 9 · Fri 1 Jan · Rinchenpong → Jorethang → Darjeeling

• ≈ 4 h via Jorethang (shared jeeps via Jorethang ₹400–500 total, or cab ₹4,000–5,000).

• Evening: Chowrasta, Mall Road, Glenary's / Keventer's, Darjeeling tea shops.

Stay: Darjeeling (₹1,500–2,500 per room; NYE-week rates) | **Day spend (per person):** ₹500–1,125 transfer + ₹700 food

Day 10 · Sat 2 Jan · Tiger Hill sunrise · Toy train · Darjeeling

• 04:00 **Tiger Hill** sunrise over Kanchenjunga (shared jeep or cab ₹1,500–2,000) → **Ghoom monastery** → **Batasia Loop**.

• **DHR toy train joyride** Darjeeling–Ghum (UNESCO; ₹800–1,500, book on IRCTC; festive specials run till 3 Jan 2027).

• Japanese Peace Pagoda, Happy Valley tea estate, HMI + Padmaja Naidu zoo (closed Thursdays).

Stay: Darjeeling | **Day spend (per person):** ₹500 cab share + ₹1,000 toy train + ₹700 food

Day 11 · Sun 3 Jan · Darjeeling → Bagdogra ✈ Hyderabad

• Leave by 07:00 (3–3.5 h; fog in the plains can slow you down). Take a midday/afternoon flight, not an early-morning one.

Day spend (per person): ₹450–875 transfer

Offbeat vs main in this plan

Place	Type	Why
Gangtok MG Marg, Rumtek, Tashi viewpoint	Main	Capital, monasteries, Kanchenjunga views
Lingdum monastery	Offbeat	Large, quiet monastery 20 km from Gangtok
Tsomgo Lake, Baba Mandir, Nathula	Main	Frozen lake, border pass, snow
Zuluk, Thambi, Nathang, Kupup	Offbeat	Old Silk Route: zig-zag road, high snow valley, frozen lakes
Aritar (Lampokhari, Mankhim)	Offbeat	Lake village in East Sikkim
Temi tea garden, Ravangla Buddha Park, Ralang	Semi-offbeat	Tea slopes and monasteries
Pelling (Skywalk, Pemayangtse, Rabdentse)	Main	West Sikkim's Kanchenjunga balcony
Khecheopalri, Kanchenjunga falls	Main	Sacred lake, waterfalls
Rinchenpong, Resum, Kaluk	Offbeat	Quiet ridge villages with big mountain views
Darjeeling: Tiger Hill, toy train, Batasia	Main	Classic hill station

Bike / scooty rentals

Where	Rates	Rules / advice
Siliguri (most choice)	Scooty ₹500–800 · 150–350 cc ₹900–1,800	WB-registered rentals can ride to Gangtok. For Tsomgo/Nathula/Silk Route, permits are needed and outside-state vehicles may be refused (Sikkim is also considering limits on two-wheelers in permit areas). Get written confirmation from the rental shop
Gangtok	Scooty ≈ ₹699 per 24 h · bikes ₹1,200–2,000	Fuel/tolls/parking extra. Fine for Gangtok–Rumtek–Ranka on dry days
Pelling / Darjeeling	Limited; ₹700–1,500	Steep roads and early dark (17:00). Taxis are simpler

Advice: don't ride to Tsomgo, Nathula or Zuluk in December. Frozen roads above 3,000 m and permit rules make reserved local vehicles with experienced drivers the right call.

Winter gear: what to buy, what to rent, and where

Budget for gear: if you own nothing warm, expect ₹4,000–6,500 one-time purchase (thermals, fleece, gloves, cap, socks, sunglasses) + ₹800–1,500 in rentals on the trip (jacket, suit, boots, spikes). The per-plan budgets include only the **rental** part; the purchases you keep are listed separately.

Item	Need	Buy (Decathlon Hyderabad / local)	Rent (where & rate)	Advice
Thermal inner set (top + bottom) ×2	Must	₹800–1,200 per set (local ₹400–600)	Not rented (hygiene)	Buy. Merino/poly, not cotton
Fleece / sweater (mid layer)	Must	₹600–1,200	—	Buy
Padded / down jacket (rated −5 to −10 °C)	Must	₹2,500–5,000	Indiahikes rentals ₹55–80/day (ships to you); trek operators ₹100/day; Manali / Gulmarg shops ₹150–300/day	Rent if you'll never use it again. 10 days ≈ ₹600–1,000
One-piece snow suit	At snow points	—	Solang/Palchan, Kufri, Gulmarg, Tsomgo ₹250–500/day (often with gumboots)	Rent on the spot only on snow days
Gumboots / snow boots	At snow points	—	₹100–200/day (Lachung ~₹100; bundled with suit at Solang ₹400–500)	Rent on the spot
Waterproof trekking shoes	Must (Plans 2, 4, 5)	₹2,000–3,500 (Decathlon MH100/MH500)	Trek operators ₹100–150/day	Buy if you'll trek again
Waterproof gloves + woollen inners	Must	₹300–900 + ₹150	—	Buy
Woollen cap / balaclava / neck gaiter	Must	₹200–400 each	—	Buy
Woollen socks (4 pairs)	Must	₹400–600	—	Buy
UV400 sunglasses	Must on snow	₹300–800	—	Snow glare causes snow-blindness
Microspikes + gaiters	Chopta, Hatu, Jalori, Gulmarg walks	₹1,200–1,800	Chopta/Sari/Sankri ₹150–250/day; gaiters ₹100/day	Rent

Rental points on this route

Point	What you can rent	Rate
Tsomgo Lake stalls (on the way)	Long coats, gumboots, gloves	₹100–200 per item
Zuluk / Nathang	Few rentals; homestays may lend gumboots	Carry your own warm layers
Lachung (if you swap in North Sikkim)	Snow boots	≈ ₹100 per pair
Gangtok Lal Market / Darjeeling Mall (buy)	Cheap jackets, gloves, caps	₹300–1,500

Budget (per person, 4 people)

Item (per person)	Shoestring	Recommended	Notes
Flight Hyderabad → Bagdogra	₹6,500	₹8,500	Book now; 24 Dec fares climb
Flight Bagdogra → Hyderabad	₹6,500	₹8,500	
Bagdogra → Gangtok	₹600	₹875	Shared vs reserved
Gangtok sightseeing cab	₹800	₹800	
Tsomgo (+ Nathula)	₹1,200	₹1,700	Shared seat Tsomgo only vs govt-fixed Nathula cab
Silk Route vehicle 2 days incl. permits	₹3,000	₹3,500	
Aritar → Ravangla → Pelling (+ Pelling local)	₹1,600	₹2,250	Shared jeeps vs cabs
Pelling → Rinchenpong → Darjeeling	₹800	₹1,575	
Darjeeling local + transfer to Bagdogra	₹850	₹1,375	
Stays, 10 nights	₹7,500	₹10,000	Dorms/homestays vs rooms (2 per room)
Food	₹4,500	₹5,000	Zuluk homestay includes meals
Toy train joyride	₹0	₹1,000	Optional
Entries, permits, misc	₹500	₹700	
Gear rentals	₹400	₹500	
Buffer	₹800	₹1,000	
TOTAL per person	**₹35,550**	**₹47,275**	**Over the ₹25–30k limit because of flights. A group of 6 saves ≈ ₹4k pp. The lean version (box above) comes to ≈ ₹31k.**

Bookings to do now

- Flights HYD⇄IXB (24 Dec out, 3 Jan midday back). Check IndiGo directly; fares rise every week from here.
- Gangtok hotel for 24–27 Dec through someone who can also arrange the Tsomgo/Nathula permit vehicle.
- Zuluk homestay (they arrange the Silk Route vehicle + Rongli permit), Darjeeling for 1–2 Jan (NYE-week demand).
- DHR joyride on IRCTC ~2–3 weeks ahead.

Plan B

- Nathula closed (snow/days): Tsomgo + Baba Mandir only (cheaper), or Hanuman Tok + Ganesh Tok half-day.

- Silk Route snowed in above Zuluk: stay low (Aritar + Rolep/Reshi), or swap to **Okhrey / Hee-Bermiok** in West Sikkim, or Lachung if it's open.
- Want North Sikkim (Lachung–Yumthang–Zero Point)? Swap Days 4–5 for a 2D/1N Gangtok package. Status changed several times in 2025–26 and Zero Point is often closed by snow, so confirm the week before.

Carry list

- Original photo ID (Aadhaar/DL) + 2 photocopies + **4 passport photos** (Sikkim permits, J&K checks).
- Power bank (cold drains batteries 2× faster), offline Google Maps, cash ₹5–8k (ATMs fail in snow areas).
- Basic meds: Diamox (only after a doctor's advice) for Nathula / Chandrashila / Zuluk, paracetamol, ORS, cold & cough tabs, band-aids, Vaseline.
- Small daypack, reusable bottle, thermos (hot water in −5 °C mornings), quick-dry towel, plastic bags for wet gear.
- Prepaid SIMs from outside J&K do not work in Kashmir. Carry at least one **postpaid** connection (Plan 3).

Safety & buffers

- Snow and roads change by the hour. Check HP/J&K/Sikkim/Uttarakhand police traffic updates and ask your homestay every evening. National emergency: **112**. HP disaster helpline: **1077**.
- Do not ride rented two-wheelers on fresh snow or black ice (Solang–Atal Tunnel, Narkanda, Gulmarg road, Chopta). Taxis with snow chains are safer after snowfall.
- Book stays for 24 Dec–1 Jan **in advance** (NYE rates in Manali/Shimla/Gulmarg/Darjeeling go 2–3× normal). Prefer free-cancellation rates.
- Keep 3 Jan as a pure buffer: plan to start the last long leg (hills → Delhi/airport) by 1 Jan, because snow and NYE traffic delay buses 3–8 h.
- High altitude (Nathula, Nathang): no alcohol the night before, climb slowly, carry dry fruits and water; turn back if headache + nausea worsen.
- Sikkim bans plastic bottles at many tourist spots. Carry a refillable bottle.

Sources checked

Reddit could not be searched from this environment (blocked), so traveller reports came from Team-BHP, Tripoto, travel blogs and local news. Live seat availability and live fares could not be fetched (IRCTC needs login and captcha). Use the checklists above to verify.

— Nathula/Tsomgo fixed taxi fares (₹6,500/₹7,000 incl. permits): India Today NE, Outlook Traveller, Club Mahindra (2024 order)
— Permit process and Silk Route permit at Rongli: muddietrails Sikkim permits, trekkingsikkim, darjeeling-tourism.com
— North Sikkim reopening reports (conflicting 2025–26 dates): WanderOn, UNI India, sikkimdarjeelingtourism, muddietrails
— Bagdogra/NJP → Gangtok shared & reserved rates: darjeeling-tourism.com, banbanjara, darjeelingtravels.in (2026)
— Bike rules: bikewalebhaiya.com Sikkim guides, ridesiliguri, newkerala (Sikkim mulls two-wheeler limits, Aug 2026)
— Trains to NJP (15645, 15673, 07572, 12513): erail/gettraininfo/ixigo/railyatri listings via search (running days conflict)
— DHR toy train joyride fares & festive specials till 3 Jan 2027: Outlook Traveller, Curly Tales, ETV Bharat, RailMitra
— HYD–IXB flights: IndiGo route page, HappyFares, Skyscanner, Kayak (Nov 2026)
— Winter offbeat ideas (Zuluk, Kecheopalri, Lachung boots): TravelTriangle, Thrillophilia, Tripoto traveller notes